

Cape buffalo

Syncerus caffer



The Cape buffalo is a massively built, oxlike hoofed mammal, and one of Africa's largest herbivores. Adult males mature at about five years of age, and weigh two-thirds more than females. Both sexes have a pair of formidable, curved horns, which in bulls almost meet across the top of the forehead, spanning up to 4 ft (1.3 m) in length. Bulls establish their dominance by displaying their horns in various threat positions and rarely fight.

Cape buffaloes have poor eyesight, and largely rely on their keen hearing to detect lions—their chief predators. Mixed herds comprise cows, their calves, and males of various ages. At certain times of the year, their numbers may reach hundreds or even thousands of animals. Bachelor herds contain five to 10 bulls.

↔ 8–11 ft (2.4–3.4 m)

⚖ 1,100–1,985 lb (500–900 kg)

⊗ Common

🌿 Grass, leaves

🏠

E. to S. Africa

▽ **QUENCHING THEIR THIRST**
Cape buffaloes eat huge quantities of grass. Their diet is thirst-inducing and they travel long distances to drink at rivers or waterholes. They also rest for many hours, digesting their food.



↔ 4–6 ft (1.3–1.8 m)

⚖ 115–298 lb (52–135 kg)

⊗ Locally common

🌿 Aquatic plants, grasses

🏠

C. Africa

△ **ON THE RUN**
Red lechwes have water-repellant hairs on their lower legs that prevent the legs becoming waterlogged as they run further into the swamp away from predators, giving them an advantage.

▷ **BATTLE FOR SUPREMACY**
Two mature males fight to take possession of a prime breeding territory. A couple of male onlookers await the outcome with interest, while the females keep their heads down and carry on grazing.